

The Heart Under the Hill

Tuesday, 18 August 2026

Played: Tuesday, 18 August 2026, 8:00 PM ET · ~3h32m recorded **Party:** Gren Greenmantle (Tom) · Jetten Elisedil (Drew) · Morgash the Gravemaker (Anthony) · Thomas A. Invictus (Robert) — all level 4 **Sites:** the Kestrel camp (staging) → **the Hollow** (rooms 01 Stairs Down, 02 Catacombs, 03 The Keeper's Seat, 04 Preparation Chamber, 05 Hollow's Heart) **Headline:** ★ **The party holds the first shard of the Broken Heart — the Graveheart.** Osric, Edda, Aldous and Cadoc destroyed; Hesper given the death she asked for.

TL;DR

They never went back to town. From the displacer-beast camp the party went straight down the shrine road to the caves Marn's journal warned them about, and found not a shrine but a catacomb: five wights, three of them five centuries old, two of them the Kestrel Company's own missing members. They fought room by room down a hole nobody had opened in five hundred years, learned from a mortician who *wanted* to die that the whole thing began with three treasure hunters who found a warm, beating crystal in a cave and could not put it down — and at the bottom, past a guardian with a burning scythe, they took it. Jetten lifted the Graveheart and saw the woman from their dreams tear her own heart out of her chest.

1 · Breaking camp (00:00–00:25)

The night opened at the ruined temple southeast of Greenrest, on top of the previous session's kill. The first twenty minutes were logistics and a rules clinic — the DM had wired up combat automation (targeting, auto-damage, weapon-mastery prompts) and walked everyone through it against a practice dummy. Drew ran the whole mastery cycle on Jetten's kit (Slow / Vex / Nick); Tom and Robert sorted out that *Bless* should go on the people who actually swing.

Loot split from the Kestrel crate:

- Gren took the **Pearl of Power**, attuned, and put the **Periapt of Wound Closure** back into the party stash to stay under three attunements (he keeps Wand of the War Mage +1, Stone of Good Luck, Pearl of Power).
- Jetten took the 17 × +1 **Arrows**.
- Morgash took 2 × **Potion of Healing (Greater)** and the **Maul of Momentum** (the DM attuned it for him) — closing out last session's open attunement question.

Choosing the site. They reread **Marn's Journal** and pulled up **Sera's Map of the Four Ruins** (the treasure-map handout). Drew read the damning entry aloud: *"It is no shrine — it is a catacomb, cut deep under the hill, the dead laid in rows in the walls. And they did not stay in them."* Anthony made the argument that carried: the Kestrels never got past the dead, so the relic is probably still in there, **and the party knows exactly what is waiting**. Robert noted the shrine is the farthest of the four from Greenrest — and said out loud he was nervous about the hag coven and the Temple of Shar. Locked: **the caves**.

Long rest taken at the camp (sun setting, several of them still chewed up from the displacer fight). Notably: **they never returned to Greenrest, so the planned Selma visit did not happen**.

2 · Down the stairs (00:23–00:38) — Room 01

A clear trail from the camp, and then a **minaret sticking out of the forest floor with a staircase going down**. Gren burned a free *Speak with Animals* on a squirrel to scout it: *"No, I don't go down there. That's not where food is. There's weird sounds, weird noises. We don't go down there."* He fed it more rations than it could carry anyway and asked it to come find him if it saw bad guys. (Gren, afterward: *"That was useless. They never give you any information."*)

Gren cast *Light* on the sun symbol of Thomas's shield. Down the spiral:

- A **statue** of living rock — robed, taller than a person, **worn past recognition: no face, no hands**. A shallow offering basin at its feet.
- A **skeleton impaled on floor spikes**, propped up by rocks jammed into the floor that were not part of the original construction — it fell, or was pushed, from above.

Thomas — Religion 19, then 21 (Survival/Medicine 21 for the corpse):

- Centuries old, not decades. **500 years, and not a scratch on it**.
- **Not dedicated to any god he knows**. No holy symbols, no scripture, no iconography of any living faith. The chisel work is wrong for tools still in use — far too many small strokes, *"the work of people with nothing but time."* Whoever cut this **was not following a tradition. They were making it up**.
- The offering basin **has never been used**. Whoever built it never brought anything to it.
- Gren's follow-up: it fits the pattern of older wandering tribes, more paganistic than theological.

Robert, out of character but worth recording: *"Is anybody else hearing all of this cackling?"* — the Hollow's soundscape (Crypt Moans / Zombie Moans) landed exactly as intended.

3 · The catacombs (00:38–00:51) — Room 02, first fight

Two doors, both into the same crypt. Morgash opened one and a **skeleton** came straight at him.

- **Jetten** opened with *Faerie Fire* (one of two skeletons failed) and *Hunter's Mark*.
- **Morgash** used *Adrenaline Rush* to close; a skeleton missed him and he answered with **Riposte** — *"your maul shatters the bones of the skeleton, destroying it."* Then a clean maul hit (17 → 13).
- **Thomas** threw a javelin (22 → 9) and applied *Slow*.
- **Jetten** put a longbow shot into the archer at advantage (28 → 11 + 4 Hunter's Mark) — *"psychic — no, force damage and piercing damage fused, and the skeleton explodes into pieces."*
- A second maul blow (17 → 13) finished the last of them.

They opened every coffin in the walls. **All empty**. Gren said a prayer over each one — *"May you rest in peace; the scourge of necromancy not..."* Jetten: *"Let the dead lie."*

4 · Aldous (00:53–01:28) — Room 02, second fight

The next door opened on **zombies, a skeleton, a skeletal archer, and a clearly undead humanoid in the center of the room**. It pointed its sword and said: *"You will join us."*

- **Gren** opened *Innate Sorcery* and put three *Scorching Ray* beams into it (17/26/14 → 3, 12, 8).
- **Aldous** closed through *Entangle* and hit Morgash with the **Necrotic Sword**, then reached out his fingers — *"Join me."* — and used **Life Drain**. Morgash passed the save and took half.
-  **The Hollowing fired for the first time:** *"The wound closes; something underneath it doesn't."* **Morgash: maximum –3, now 38/45.** This is the dungeon's whole design in one line, and it landed — the table understood immediately that this was different from ordinary damage.
- **Gren** cast *Shatter* through **Subtle Spell** (everything saved) and used **Spellfire Burst** to add radiant to Aldous.
- **Jetten** dropped *Entangle*; the zombies mostly broke out of it.
- **Morgash** switched to the **Greataxe**, missed, spent a superiority die on **Precision Attack** (25 → 9), and used **Cleave** for the follow-up.
- Aldous drained Morgash a second time — **maximum –6, now 35/42.**
- **Gren** killed a zombie with *Fire Bolt* (20 → 5) — *"Kill it, send it back to its grave."*
-  **Thomas killed Aldous** with **First Light** (18 → 13). Morgash used **Second Wind** (9).

The body. Thomas rolled Religion **21**: wights are corpses whose wickedness sustains them past death — *"but this one doesn't look like a typical wight you've read about."* On its throat: a **Kestrel Company Locket**. In its hand: a **Necrotic Sword**, *"too cold for you to touch."* Gren wrapped it in cloth rather than handle it, and both went to the party stash.

Robert made the connection that framed the rest of the night, straight out of Marn's journal: **"Aldous's wounds closed, but he did not mend. Edda would not leave him."** — the same words the DM had just used for Morgash. His fear, stated plainly: *"I'd be afraid of having an orc that turns into a wight."* Thomas held up his Holy Symbol of Lathander and said a prayer over the corpse.

Character beat — the Everseed Acorn. Prompted by the talk of undying things, Gren showed the party the acorn his village elders pressed into his hand the day they sent him north: from the heart-oak of his warren, still green after years, to be planted **when he finds the place he belongs**. His line: **"I still have not found the place where I belong."**

They debated resting. The DM: *"In all your years adventuring, you would never take a long rest in a tomb filled with undead."* They pressed on.

5 · Osric, the Keeper (01:29–02:26) — Room 03, the big fight

The doors opened on a long pillared hall, a platform at the far end in the dark, **two more wights, a crowd of skeletons, and a wight on a throne who beckoned them forward**. Gren took out the Driftglobe. Morgash's darkvision carried the room.

The parley (short, exactly as designed):

- Gren: *"Should we come in and parlay with these undead?"* Osric: *"Come in."*
- Jetten: *"What have you done with Edda, Aldous's companion?"* Osric: **"She's here. She's with us. She's happier."**
- Thomas: **"Why shouldn't we just destroy you here and now?"**
- Osric: **"You know, I thought you would be interesting, but your insolence irritates me. You will not make a suitable wight — you'll make an excellent zombie."**

The fight (initiative: Jetten 21, Skeleton 20, Edda 18, Osric 14, Morgash 14, Thomas 14, Gren 4):

- **Jetten crit** the skeletal archer with the longbow (28 → 8 + 10 Hunter's Mark, both doubled).
- **Edda** — a caster, as Marn's journal implied — cast **Hold Person** and **paralyzed Jetten**.
- **Morgash** answered: *Adrenaline Rush* to close, missed, spent **Precision Attack** (1d8 = 8 → 30 total) for 13 and a **Topple** that knocked her prone. She held concentration (19 vs DC 10). Then **Action Surge** → 27 → **26 damage** → concentration check 4 vs DC 13 → **broken. Jetten free**. The single best sequence of the night.

- **Osric** worked Morgash over with Life Drain: **maximum -9 (39/39)**, later **-14 (34/34)**, and after Edda's own drain **-21 (27/27)**.
- **Thomas** hit with First Light + **Sap**, used **Shield Master** to bash a skeleton prone (STR save 2), then cast **Bane** on Osric, Edda and the mage — **only the Skeletal Mage failed**.
- 💡 **The turning point — Gren opened the Driftglobe as daylight.** *"The entire room illuminates with daylight, and as soon as you do it, Osric and Edda shriek and recoil from it."* **Sunlight Sensitivity:** disadvantage on every attack the wights made for the rest of the fight.
- The **Skeletal Mage** countered intelligently — **Darkness** centered on the globe, trapping the daylight inside a 15-foot sphere. Gren spent his next turn **physically carrying the one-pound globe out of the darkness** to restore it.
- **Edda** tried **Command** on Morgash; he shook it off (21). Morgash's maul answered — the same weapon that had broken her spell — and **Edda went down**. Her locket and a second **Necrotic Sword** were recovered from the body.
- **Gren** cast **Shield** twice off Osric's and the mage's attacks (AC 15 → 20, both missed), **Misty Step**-ed clear, and upcast **Magic Missile** at 3rd level (16). He also ate a big Necrotic Sword hit (20 → 16 damage) and later a Life Drain — **maximum -3, now 7/23**.
- **Thomas** cast **Divine Favor**, **crit** with First Light (27 → 17), and took Life Drain twice — **maximum -3 (24/33)**, then **-7 (25/29)** — holding *Bane* concentration through every hit.
- **Jetten** worked the Goldthorn/Shortsword **Nick + Vex** weave into Osric at advantage while he was prone (26 and 23).
- ✂ **Thomas killed Osric** (14 → 14 damage). Asked how he wanted to do it: ***"I don't like this guy, so I'm going to chop his head off."*** — *"You swing your sword and the wight's head flies up in the air, plops on the ground, and rolls down the stairs."*
- **Morgash** crushed the last Skeletal Mage with the maul (23 → 13, **double damage** vs skeleton). Jetten had already broken its *Darkness* concentration with a Goldthorn hit (save 1 vs DC 10).

Robert's running commentary through the fight is the best of the night: *"Not so cocky now, are you, Osric?"* · *"You should have talked to us, Osric."* · *"I hate Osric."*

After: the throne and surrounds gave up nothing. **The west doors were locked; the east doors open.** Everyone took a **short rest** (Jetten spent 3 hit dice, Gren 2, Morgash 1, Thomas 1), and the table got a useful clinic on short rests, hit dice and superiority-die recovery.

6 · Hesper, the Mortician (02:32–02:42) — Room 04

Through the east doors: **a wight flanked by two zombies, on a dais.** She looked up and did not fight. This is the scene of the session.

"She sees blood on you where you're from, and she says: you came through the crypts. That means Osric is finally dead, or you would not be standing in that doorway."

"He was very old and very tired. I hope he was courteous with you. He usually managed courteous — at least, he used to. He doesn't suffer insolence well."

"I am Hesper. I will answer plainly. No need for riddles, no need for bargaining. To be honest, I haven't even talked to anyone in a very long time. What is your question?"

The origin of everything, in her own words:

*"Three hundred, four hundred, five hundred years ago — Osric, Cadoc and I, we were treasure hunters. We found a glowing shard in a cave. **It was warm, beating, the size of two cupped hands.** We saw it; we couldn't put it down. We brought it here to keep it safe. After time, our greed turned into undeath. We cut the stair so no one else could take it. We cut every way in that we knew. And so we stood with the Graveheart — **lonely** — but it gave us life. It's here, guarded by Cadoc, waiting for the next body to be prepared as a wight to keep us company."*

"But I'm tired. I don't want to do this anymore."

On Cadoc: *"He's the one closest to it, the one most inured with it. He won't speak to you like I speak to you. He will only seek to protect what is his and try and kill you. **There is no bargaining with Cadoc.**"* On the zombies: *"They won't hurt you, and when I die they will die with me."* Morgash asked whether she could reverse what the drain had done — she could not.

She told them to take what was in the chest: **Hesper's Bone Key** (for the locked west doors) and the **Draught of Wholeness** — *"I have no use for either anymore. I'm sure you will need them both."* Also recovered: a sickle and a dagger.

The mercy. Gren asked how she would like it done. *"She walks up to the platform and lays her head on it."* A coup de grace, and **Hesper's body rolled off the slab — and both zombies collapsed where they stood, simultaneously.**

 **Attribution unclear:** Gren offered the honor to Thomas, but the only attack rolled at that moment is **Jetten's Goldthorn** (19 → 6). Recorded here as ambiguous rather than guessed.

The Draught of Wholeness — only one. Morgash drank it: *"All of the hit points that you lost and all the wounds that wouldn't close, they suddenly feel like they're settled back, and the darkness from you is gone."* → **No Longer Hollowed, restored to 27/48.**

Gren's Religion 18 answered the party's real question: a solid night's sleep — **in a real bed, not a dungeon** — will fully close the drained maximums. That is the standing cure the party now believes in.

Second short rest; Gren upcast **Bless at 2nd level** to cover all four. Gren: *"Let's charge in, because it's time. The clock is ticking."*

7 · Cadoc, the Guardian (02:58–03:28) — Room 05, Hollow's Heart

The west doors, unlocked with Hesper's key, opened on the payoff room: **a hooded figure with a scythe wreathed in necrotic fire; a ritual altar; a heap of skeletons with glowing eyes** — and, mounted in a container, **a large crystalline heart**.

(The Graveheart itself rolled initiative, being an artifact — briefly alarming: *"Graveheart's an adversary?!"*)

Initiative: Cadoc 26, Jetten 24, Gren 21, Graveheart 20, Skeletal Mage 16, Thomas 15, Morgash 11.

- **Cadoc** opened at range with the **Necrotic Bow**, then used his legendary action **Necrofire Reach** on Thomas across the chamber (9 necrotic) — **Thomas: maximum –16, now 20/20**.
 - **Jetten**, riding *Bless*, hit for 31 → 14.
 - **Morgash** was the engine: *Adrenaline Rush*, **Precision Attack** for a **35** total → 13 and a **Topple** that put Cadoc prone, then **Action Surge** → 28 → 8.
 - **Thomas** worked First Light + **Sap** to keep Cadoc at disadvantage, spent his **last spell slot on Divine Smite (3d8 = 18, with the extra die for undead)**, and used **Shield Master** twice.
 - **Gren** was out of his best options — *Fire Bolt*, then **Guiding Bolt** twice (the second hit, 20 → 10, handing advantage to the next attacker), and could not get a heal to land where it mattered.
 - The **Skeletal Mage** was a menace to the end: *Darkness* again, *Ice Knife*, and **Magic Missile**.
 - Cadoc's scythe and Life Drain kept coming — **Thomas: maximum –20, now 10/16**. Cadoc took a drain-back himself (–5, 92/122).
 -  **Magic Missile dropped Morgash to 0 — and Relentless Endurance caught him at 1 HP**. He tried **Second Wind** (5, *"it just doesn't turn out"*), drank a **Greater Healing Potion**, and spent an **inspiration** to re-roll.
 -  **The kill**. Cadoc swung the scythe at Morgash and **rolled a 1**. Morgash took the **Riposte** reaction (8), then brought the **Maul of Momentum** down (22 → 16): *"The maul crushes his skull."* The zombies and skeletons were mopped up as an afterthought.
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8 · ★ The Graveheart (03:28)

"You stand victorious. In front of you is the Graveheart."

Jetten took it. The vision fired:

"Jetten, as you grab it, you see a vision. A beautiful green woman, glowing, white leaves crowning her head. She's crying. As she sobs, she closes her hands over her chest — and her heart bursts. The pieces scatter into the dark, hardening as they fly. The burst drives the mists back where she's standing, in a great ring, bearing a bare green valley next to a beautiful lake. Where she stood: a tree. Gray, lifeless, and asleep. You hear a single faint heartbeat. And it's over."

The party recognised the woman instantly — she is the one all four of them dreamed. Nobody said the word "Greenrest" out loud, but the gray tree in the vision is the gray tree in the square, and the table knew it.

Session ended there, in the Hollow's Heart, with the shard in the party stash and everyone battered. Their stated intent: get out and get back to camp.

Ledger

Shards of the Broken Heart: 1 / 4.

Gained

- ★ **The Graveheart** (artifact) — party stash
- **Hesper's Bone Key** — Morgash
- **Draught of Wholeness** — *consumed by Morgash*
- **3 × Kestrel Company Locket** (Aldous, Edda, + one more) — party stash
- **3 × Necrotic Sword** — party stash
- Sickle, dagger — party stash
- 17 × +1 Arrows → Jetten · Pearl of Power → Gren (attuned) · Maul of Momentum → Morgash (attuned)
- Periapt of Wound Closure → returned to party stash (unattuned)

Slain

- **Osric, the Keeper** — Thomas (beheaded)
- **Cadoc, the Guardian** — Morgash (riposte into a maul blow)

- **Aldous** (Kestrel Company) — Thomas
- **Edda** (Kestrel Company) — Morgash
- **Hesper, the Mortician** — by her own request, on the slab (hand ambiguous)
- ~8 skeletons / skeletal archers / skeletal mages, ~5 zombies

Conditions carried out of the session

- **Hollowed:** Gren (−3), Thomas (−20), Morgash (−5). Jetten untouched.
- Party HP at close: Morgash 6, Thomas 15, Gren 23, Jetten 32.

Not done: the Selma visit. The party never returned to Greenrest.

Recorded at the table — transcribed & chronicled by the party scribe.